

Interactive Digital Art and Design SE608

Project Proposal Year IV



Student Name:	Natalia Ryl	Student Number:	C00294480
Working Title:	Until the Secret Surfaces - Animation Dingle Game Sting Submission		
Description:	An interactive narrative-driven 2D visual novel developed using the Ren'Py engine, tailored for submission to Animation Dingle and aligned with the 'MOVE ME' theme. The game follows an undercover journalist over a period of 7 days in a coastal Irish town called Dingle. The journalist is driven originally by the want of getting a big headline about the town's secret before realising how that would impact the town and its people. To bring this narrative to life and meet advanced computing standards by going beyond basic engine limits, I am building custom Python scripts and screen layouts from scratch. The project includes a trust system that tracks relationships across 5 key characters, custom state management to run a 7-day clock and an interactive journal UI that updates the user as they piece together the mystery. Since this game is aimed for the submission for Animation Dingle and I am aware the deadline for a finished game will be much earlier than the final year project's deadline, I am planning to use a streamlined story path with fewer roadblocks so it reaches the end of game faster, with possibly one or two endings and a very short animatic as an ending scene. Then for the final year project I would expand the deeper relationship trackers and add extra endings and maybe even expand on the animatic ending scenes. To make the game look and run professionally, I am asking the college for a license for Live2D Cubism PRO. While I can start using the free trial, a full license is needed to finish the project because: Live2D works smoothly and natively with the Ren'Py engine. On the other hand, Spine does not have official Ren'Py support yet, which means I would have to use complicated, unofficial workarounds that could easily break. Live2D uses a mesh warping system that keeps the hand-drawn look completely intact while letting characters breathe, blink, and move naturally. Spine is built more like a skeleton for side-scrolling games, which doesn't fit a visual novel style. Using Live2D PRO allows me to build advanced mesh rigging and physics-based animations, proving my technical and visual computing skills for my final-year project in a way basic sprites cannot.		
Reasons for selecting project:	I chose this project because it gives me a great opportunity to explore my passion for art by creating my own assets and characters and even possibly creating a short cinematic animation for the ending. At the same time, developing a visual		

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	novel lets me explore a new engine, Ren'Py, that I have learned about in my work placement in Italy. It also allows me to further develop my knowledge in the new language I am learning currently, Python. In addition to all that aiming for Animation Dingle gives me a clear goal, allowing me to build a polished story that blends my coding and art with Irish folklore.
Proposed research content:	I am researching how players feel emotions in games. I am referencing the study Action Before Empathy: How Player Agency Shapes Emotional Connection in Interactive Narrative to support how letting players make real choices over a short timeline helps them care more about the character and the story's ending. I am also researching how to use local heritage in games. I am referencing the article Bridging Heritage and Innovation: How Digital Gaming Preserves Cultural Symbols to support how old local folklore can be turned into a modern digital story. I am also researching backend state-machine architecture and engine extension. I'm referencing the technical study Developing decision-making serious games using Ren'Py visual novel engine to support how custom scripting and logic layers can be built on top of standard visual novel frameworks to manage complex choice tracking.
External links (if applicable):	Animation Dingle Game Sting: https://animationdingle.com/game-stings/ Main inspiration for relationship-trust based visual novel that has different endings based on player choices: Doki Doki Literature Club Live2D Cubism in Ren'Py: Live2D Cubism — Ren'Py Documentation
Hardware requirements:	Lab computer Personal Laptop - owned Wacom tablet - owned
Software requirements:	Ren'Py SDK (Python-based visual novel engine) Digital painting software such as Krita/Clip Studio Paint Live2D Cubism PRO GitHub Itch.io
Other requirements:	

Signed:

Date: 25/09/2026

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Natalia Ryl

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Approved/Not Approved:		
Reasons for not approving project:		
Conditions attached to approving project:		
Approved/Not Approved:		
Name of Supervisor:		
Signed: _____	Date: _____	